often lacked adequate training. Frequently starved of information and scapegoated for failures, commanders also had to cope with political commissars who could dispute their decisions. The safest course was to wait for orders from on high and then slavishly follow them even when they made little military sense.[119]

Despite the disasters of 1941 and of the spring and summer of 1942, the Soviet state did not collapse, as Hitler hoped. As the Red Army and the Soviet leadership assimilated the lessons learned from the first year of struggle, the political centre in Moscow loosened its hold. The power of political commissars was restricted, while professional officers were encouraged to assume greater responsibility and take more initiative.[120] Stalin also reversed his geopolitical mistakes of 1939–41 and allied the USSR with Britain and the United States. Red Army initiative, Western assistance and the realisation of what Nazi rule would mean for the people of the USSR turned the tide of the war.

Once victory was secured in 1945, however, Stalin initiated new waves of terror, purging more independent-minded officers and officials and again encouraging blind obedience.[121] Ironically, Stalin's own death eight years later was partly the result of an information network that prioritised order and disregarded truth. In 1951–53 the USSR experienced yet another witch hunt. Soviet mythmakers fabricated a conspiracy theory that Jewish doctors were systematically murdering leading regime members, under the guise of giving them medical care. The theory alleged that the doctors were the agents of a global American–Zionist plot, working in collaboration with traitors in the secret police. By early 1953 hundreds of doctors and secret police officials, including the head of the secret police himself, were arrested, tortured and forced to name accomplices. The conspiracy theory – a Soviet twist on the *Protocols of the Elders of Zion* – merged with age-old blood-libel accusations, and rumours began circulating that Jewish doctors were not just murdering Soviet leaders but also killing babies in hospitals. Since a large proportion of Soviet doctors were Jews, people began fearing doctors in general.[122]

Just as the hysteria about 'the doctors' plot' was reaching its climax, Stalin had a stroke on 1 March 1953. He collapsed in his dacha, wet himself and lay for hours in his soiled pyjamas, unable to call for help. At around 10:30 p.m. a guard found the courage to enter the inner sanctum of world